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Title of the article: *Development and Peace Through Traditional, Cultural, Islamic Mediation*

The content extracted is as follows:

Seeking Peace at the Local Level

Therefore, whether seeking to make amends for an offence, or pursuing peace for the sake of aiding development, everyone who works in a Muslim society should become familiar with the local traditions of conflict resolution.

Local conditions represent the core life experiences for Muslims in a traditional society.

As Hayman (2013) concludes from a review of peacebuilding, Locally-led peacebuilding offers advantages over internationally-led initiatives for fostering self-help, relevance and sustainability (p. 17).

Given the significance of local conflicts for the people involved, for those who seek greater human welfare in Muslim societies, and for security and stability at the regional level, local practices of mediation and conflict resolution carry great importance today.

This article uses the word local to mean that particular place where someone wants to promote peace, whether they work for a nongovernmental organisation (NGO) in aid, relief and development, healthcare, or even providing security assistance to the government.

In the context of traditional Muslim societies, local traditions of mediation and conflict resolution vary in their terminology, the content of rituals for reconciliation, preferences for mediation by a single individual or a group, and the methods of enforcing decisions.

These societies emphasise relationships and community, in contrast to the individualistic, task orientation common in the West. As Funk (2014) explains it, The forms of conflict mediation presented here seek, not merely peace as the absence of conflict, but more importantly restorative justice, meaning the reintegration of the offender back into the community, after accepting responsibility, and making reparations, in a public ritual that allows all sides to recover their dignity, thereby preventing cycles of retribution. Despite the patriarchy commonly found in Muslim societies, women of dynamic intellect and distinctive personality, like the famous woman Sufi, Rabi'a of Basra, do influence their societies (Keddie, 1987; Schimmel, 1982).

Traditional conflict mediation in Muslim societies rests on the example of the Prophet Muhammad, on many verses in the Qur'an, and on historical examples of noble individuals.

Roots of Peace in the Example of the Prophet

Understanding Islamic doctrines regarding peacebuilding requires recognising exceptions to the stereotype that the verses of the Quran given during the Muslims' sojourn in Medina promote violence and conflict.

He furthermore cites the Qur'an 5:2 to say that Muslims should not be involved in violence at all and should settle conflicts peacefully (Abu Nimer, 2010, p. 83).

What if the local peacemaker, or group of white beards who mediate conflicts, lacks the education and level of knowledge to access all the treasury of peacebuilding skills and ideas available in Islam?

In a traditional Muslim society, mediators with a reputation for humility, honour, and piety will draw inspiration and knowledge from local history and traditions, as well as the Qur'an, hadith, and the Sunnah (the path or example of the Prophet).

Character and Reputation

Gellner observed that the society he studied had been stable for 300 years under the social system in which people went to the local saint for mediation of their disputes (p. 278).

Variation in Local Practices and the Power of Symbolism

Even though a broad variety of societies make the foundations of Islam the guiding principles of social life, different Islamic cultures demonstrate a great deal of variation in customs for conflict resolution.

Somaliland achieved its cessation of hostilities and also longer-term stability through a series of no less than thirty-eight clan-based peace and reconciliation conferences and meetings between 1990 and 1997. Ibrahim and Terlinden credit success to the fact that the local communities paid the expenses of the meetings, key figures participated voluntarily, and they adopted resolutions by consensus.

Ali, Mohammed, and Walls argue that the peace meetings emphasised the importance of forgetting grievances and starting fresh, the local nature of the process, the crucial role of the elders, and the personal commitment to peace by the prominent mediators (p. 89).

In sum, Somaliland stands as a testament to the power of reconciliation using local initiative, traditional Islamic principles, and respect for the elders as men of peace.

Another important case that illustrates the traditions and principles of Islamic peacebuilding in larger conflicts can be found in the resolution of the Tajik Civil War.

In contrast, a sustained dialogue process seeks the maximum involvement and participation of society at the local level.

In sum, in Tajikistan, the supportive social and cultural environment for peacebuilding developed largely through local initiatives, with a spark from the Sustained Dialogue (Lederach, 1997).

This reflects the arguments of Funk and Said (2009) regarding seeking peace through local, traditional culture: Islamic approaches to conflict resolution draw on religious values, social networks, rituals of reconciliation, and historical practices of communal and inter-communal coexistence (p. 173).

In other words, efforts to support development and building peace in a traditional Muslim society can benefit from learning about the local culture and the principles of conflict management in Islam.

Conclusion

On the other hand, understanding that Islam offers significant resources for Muslims to use in building peace awakens the understanding to fresh possibilities in solving problems, reducing conflicts, improving communication, and promoting human development.

Muslim conflict mediators use Islamic values, combined with local examples and traditions, to solve problems and preserve peace in a variety of ways, distinctive to each society.